

## REVIEW

# After the last Ozempic injection

## REFERENCES

31 verified

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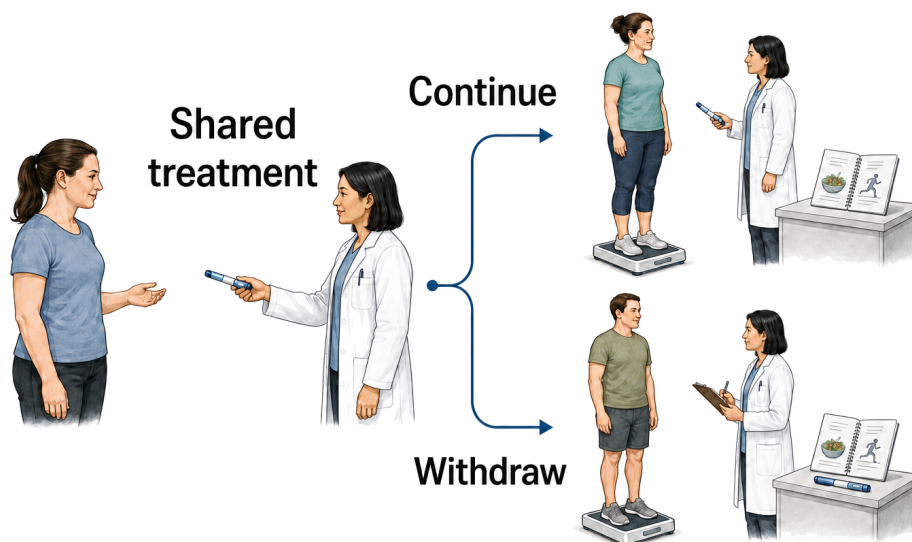
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*What happens when you stop taking Ozempic? Trials have followed people beyond their final dose, revealing which changes last and which begin to fade.*

Rubino and colleagues gave everyone in their withdrawal trial the same beginning: twenty weeks of semaglutide, followed by a random assignment to keep taking it or switch to placebo.<sup>1</sup> Over the next 48 weeks, the continuing group lost more weight, while the

switch group regained it.<sup>1</sup> The average changes were -7.9% with continued treatment and +6.9% after switching.<sup>1</sup>

The study structure is shown in [Figure 1](#).



**Figure 1. A shared start makes withdrawal testable.** Rubino randomized participants after a common semaglutide run-in to continue treatment or switch to placebo.<sup>1</sup> Both groups continued lifestyle intervention.<sup>1</sup> The branching clinic scenes depict that comparison. Pens and scales denote treatment and follow-up, not individual outcomes.

That experiment puts a concrete question behind the familiar one about stopping. How much of a treatment's benefit survives when treatment ends? The randomized withdrawal trial found weight regain after the placebo

switch.<sup>1</sup> A longer extension also found regain after treatment ended.<sup>2</sup> Together, they make weight the clearest part of the answer. Appetite, blood sugar and the

possibilities for maintaining a loss need their own evidence.

Ozempic is injectable semaglutide, introduced for type 2 diabetes.<sup>3</sup> The STEP 1 withdrawal extension studied semaglutide 2.4 mg in adults without diabetes.<sup>2</sup> If you are asking about your own future, that distinction matters: the studies describe particular people taking particular regimens, rather than every situation in which a prescription ends.

## 01 THE FIRST CHANGE IS GRADUAL

The molecule does not disappear as soon as an injection is missed. Yang and Yang's review of human drug-handling studies describes a long elimination half-life that supports weekly injections.<sup>3</sup> The half-life describes how slowly the drug clears.<sup>3</sup> Knudsen and Lau describe how semaglutide's reversible binding to albumin prolongs its action.<sup>4</sup>

These measurements establish gradual elimination. They do not give you an exact date for a returning appetite. To see what might change as exposure falls, researchers first had to measure what the drug does while people take it.

Blundell's team offered volunteers meals and snacks they could eat freely.<sup>5</sup> During semaglutide treatment, they ate about a quarter less across those meals than during placebo treatment.<sup>5</sup> In a later experiment, Friedrichsen and colleagues found less hunger, fewer or weaker cravings and better control of eating with the obesity-treatment dose.<sup>6</sup> Researchers testing oral semaglutide also found reduced food intake and appetite in adults with obesity.<sup>7</sup> A separate diabetes study found greater fullness after a fat-rich breakfast.<sup>8</sup> A review of randomized trials of GLP-1 drugs, the class that includes semaglutide, reached the same broad conclusion about appetite suppression.<sup>9</sup>

Here, the distinction between measurement and inference matters. Blundell measured food intake during treatment.<sup>5</sup> Friedrichsen measured appetite during treatment.<sup>6</sup> Their results make a return of appetite pressure after stopping plausible; they do not describe a measured day-by-day hunger curve after the final injection.

Nor does a simple story about food sitting in the stomach explain everything. At the later treatment assessment, Friedrichsen's group found no evidence of delayed gastric emptying using paracetamol absorption as an indirect test.<sup>6</sup> Gabe's oral-semaglutide experiment reported the

same late-treatment null finding.<sup>7</sup> Neither result rules out earlier or individual gastric effects.

## 02 THEN THE PATHS SEPARATE

During active treatment, the weight findings are consistent. In STEP 1, Wilding and colleagues reported a mean weight change of -14.9% with semaglutide.<sup>10</sup> Garvey's STEP 5 team reported a mean weight change of -15.2% with semaglutide at week 104.<sup>11</sup> Moiz and colleagues found substantial long-term weight loss relative to placebo.<sup>12</sup> Bergmann's review describes similar losses across the STEP trials.<sup>13</sup> Gudzone and Kushner's broader medication review also found a substantial semaglutide advantage.<sup>14</sup>

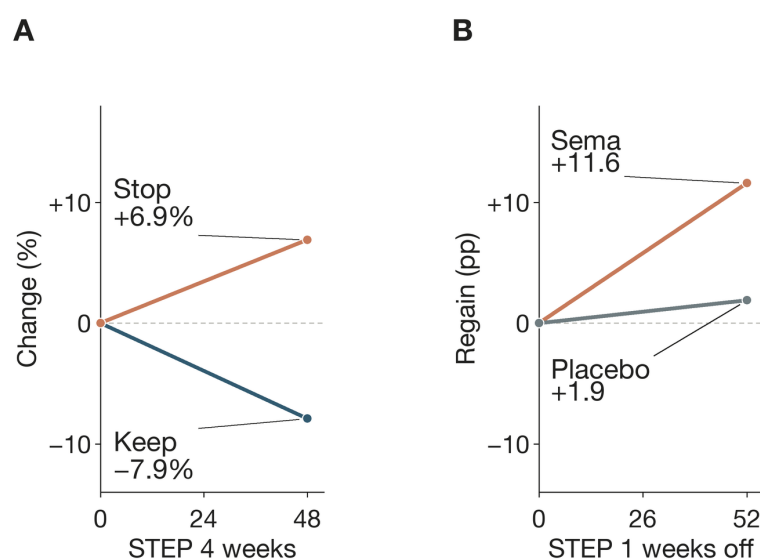
Rubino's withdrawal experiment asked whether that benefit needed continued treatment. Both randomized groups kept their lifestyle intervention, yet the people switched to placebo gained weight while those continuing semaglutide lost more.<sup>1</sup> Only people who had reached the maintenance dose were randomized.<sup>1</sup> Random assignment makes this a particularly useful comparison for separating withdrawal from continued treatment.

Wilding's STEP 1 extension followed participants for another year after treatment ended.<sup>2</sup> Former semaglutide recipients regained about two-thirds of their earlier loss, but still averaged less than their starting weight.<sup>2</sup> Among participants with available follow-up data, 48.2% retained at least 5% weight loss.<sup>2</sup> The word "regain" therefore describes a direction, not a claim that everyone returned to the beginning.

The main weight result is visible in Figure 2: continued treatment and withdrawal send the averages in opposite directions.

## 03 AVERAGES ACQUIRE A MISLEADING PRECISION

West and colleagues assembled cessation studies across weight-management medicines.<sup>15</sup> For newer incretin medicines, including semaglutide and tirzepatide, their model estimated average regain of 0.8 kg per month.<sup>15</sup> That sounds temptingly like a personal timetable. It is a study-level average.



**Figure 2. Weight rises after treatment ends.** Panel A shows percent change from week-20 weight over 48 weeks after randomization. Panel B shows regain over 52 weeks after withdrawal, in percentage points (pp) of original baseline weight; its zero is the week-68 withdrawal visit. The withdrawal trial compared continuation with a placebo switch.<sup>1</sup> In the STEP 1 extension, medication and lifestyle support ended.<sup>2</sup> Lines connect endpoints, not measured weekly paths. No uncertainty intervals are plotted. “Sema” means semaglutide. “Keep” denotes continuation; “Stop” denotes the placebo switch. In the STEP 1 extension, former semaglutide and placebo participants regained 11.6 and 1.9 percentage points of original baseline weight, respectively, over 52 weeks after withdrawal.<sup>2</sup>

The researchers had no more than a year of post-cessation observation for the newer medicines; the later trajectory was projected.<sup>15</sup> A line continuing into the future is doing a different job from a measurement collected there.

Other syntheses reinforce the direction while showing why one number cannot fit every setting. Berg's team found that larger initial losses were followed by larger re-

gain.<sup>16</sup> Tzang and colleagues found regain across randomized obesity trials, with very large differences between studies.<sup>17</sup> Quarenghi's review likewise described regain after interruption of several related medicines.<sup>18</sup> These syntheses should be read as summaries of studies, not added together as independent replications.

| EVIDENCE WINDOW          | RESULT AFTER STOPPING                                               | BOUNDARY                                                      |
|--------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Withdrawal trial         | +6.9% over 48 weeks <sup>1</sup>                                    | Lifestyle intervention continued; maintenance-dose completers |
| STEP 1 extension         | 11.6 percentage points over 1 year <sup>2</sup>                     | Medication and lifestyle intervention both ended              |
| Newer-incretin syntheses | Monthly regain: 0.8 kg; interval 0.7–0.9 <sup>15</sup>              | Study-level estimate; observation no longer than 12 months    |
| PCOS cohort              | About one-third of prior loss regained over two years <sup>19</sup> | Small uncontrolled cohort continuing metformin                |

#### 04 BLOOD TESTS FOLLOW THE SCALE

Kosiborod and colleagues examined the STEP trials beyond body weight.<sup>20</sup> Waist size, systolic blood pressure, fasting glucose, insulin and lipids improved during STEP 4's common treatment period, then deteriorated after the placebo switch while remaining improved with continued

semaglutide.<sup>20</sup> In STEP 1, several benefits also moved back toward baseline after withdrawal, although some remained at the end of follow-up.<sup>2</sup> Wilkinson's team reported a similar pattern in a calculated diabetes-risk score.<sup>21</sup> A calculated risk score is not an observed diagnosis.

Tzang's pooled analysis also tracked glycated haemoglobin, HbA<sub>1c</sub>.<sup>17</sup> It rose after GLP-1 treatment

ended, with a larger average rise in the diabetes studies than in the obesity studies.<sup>17</sup> Variation between studies was especially large for that diabetes estimate.<sup>17</sup>

These findings support moderate confidence that several metabolic improvements commonly diminish after cessation. They cannot settle the fate of every clinical benefit. Lincoff's SELECT trial found fewer major cardiovascular events with semaglutide during randomized treatment assignment.<sup>22</sup> That comparison does not directly test how long protection lasts after stopping. A change in a blood test cannot answer the missing event question.

### 05 THE PRESCRIPTION DOES NOT ALWAYS END NEATLY

Rodriguez and colleagues looked at routine US care and found that stopping and restarting were both common.<sup>23</sup> Their records tell a less orderly story than a scheduled trial withdrawal. In Gasoyan's chart review, cost or insurance problems were the most frequently recorded

reason for stopping; side effects and shortages were also recorded.<sup>24</sup>

### 06 SOME PEOPLE KEEP MORE OF THE LOSS

Must the average be everyone's outcome? Jensen and colleagues tested a promising complication: supervised exercise alongside liraglutide, a related GLP-1 medicine.<sup>25</sup> Across the year of treatment and the year after it ended, the combination group numerically retained more weight and fat loss than the liraglutide-only group, but these comparisons did not meet the prespecified multiple-testing threshold.<sup>25</sup> That total-period comparison does not isolate an advantage during the year after withdrawal. The drug was different, and follow-up was incomplete.<sup>25</sup> It is an encouraging clue for semaglutide, rather than a demonstrated replacement for it.

The timing of that study matters, as [Figure 3](#) shows.



**Figure 3. Measure maintenance after treatment ends.** Jensen combined supervised exercise with liraglutide and assessed participants after treatment ended.<sup>25</sup> This was a liraglutide study.<sup>25</sup> The temporal path separates active treatment from later weighing; it does not depict a weight-loss magnitude.

Patients with longer medication coverage also lost more weight on average in Gasoyan's clinical cohorts.<sup>26,27</sup> The discontinuation analysis used a retrospective cohort.<sup>26</sup> The earlier semaglutide/liraglutide comparison also used a retrospective cohort.<sup>27</sup> Access, dose and the characteristics of people who continue can contribute to the gap; the

cohorts cannot assign the entire difference to stopping alone.

Gleason measured one-year GLP-1 persistence.<sup>28</sup> Gasoyan reported one-year persistence across anti-obesity medications and for semaglutide.<sup>29</sup>

Jensterle's team followed a small group of women with polycystic ovary syndrome who continued metformin

after semaglutide ended.<sup>19</sup> They regained only about a third of their prior loss over two years, but several metabolic improvements returned to baseline.<sup>19</sup> The study had no control group.<sup>19</sup> It therefore cannot establish that metformin caused the better weight maintenance.

McKenzie and Athinarayanan also reported maintained weight in selected patients who stopped GLP-1 treatment while continuing a carbohydrate-restricted telemedicine program.<sup>30</sup> That comparison used a retrospective cohort, too.<sup>30</sup>

The larger picture is less reassuring than either small cohort alone. West's synthesis found no evidence that post-cessation behavioral support changed regain rates across the included studies.<sup>15</sup> Dash's review likewise calls for randomized testing of proposed lifestyle strategies.<sup>31</sup> Different interventions and selected populations leave room for benefit, but no broadly reliable semaglutide transition protocol emerges from these results.

## 07 WHAT THE NEXT TRIAL NEEDS TO FOLLOW

Return to Rubino's two groups. Their divergent paths give strong evidence that continuing semaglutide maintains weight benefit better than withdrawing it among people who reach the study dose.<sup>1</sup> The extension found regain

and loss of several metabolic improvements.<sup>2</sup> The randomized metabolic analysis found deterioration after the placebo switch.<sup>20</sup> Together, these results support moderate confidence in a common pattern of regain and diminishing benefits.

The next useful experiment would follow people from their final semaglutide dose, randomly compare realistic maintenance strategies, and keep measuring hunger, weight and blood sugar together. It would test which people can preserve which benefits, for how long. That is the unanswered question behind the last injection.

**Scope and methods.** Narrative review; searches rerun on 4 September 2026 in PubMed, with backward and forward OpenAlex citation chasing. Focused on journal-indexed adult human evidence on semaglutide, with explicitly identified related-drug evidence and broader reviews; excluded anecdotes and preprints. The saved access manifest contains twelve authenticated full texts, eleven cited here; remaining cited material was abstract-level, including the direct STEP 4 report. Outcome confidence reflects design, bias, inconsistency, indirectness and imprecision; it is separate from whether a quotation supports a sentence. Related trial reports are grouped, and overlapping reviews are not counted as independent confirmation.

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[github.com/jostelzer/grounded](https://github.com/jostelzer/grounded)

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